

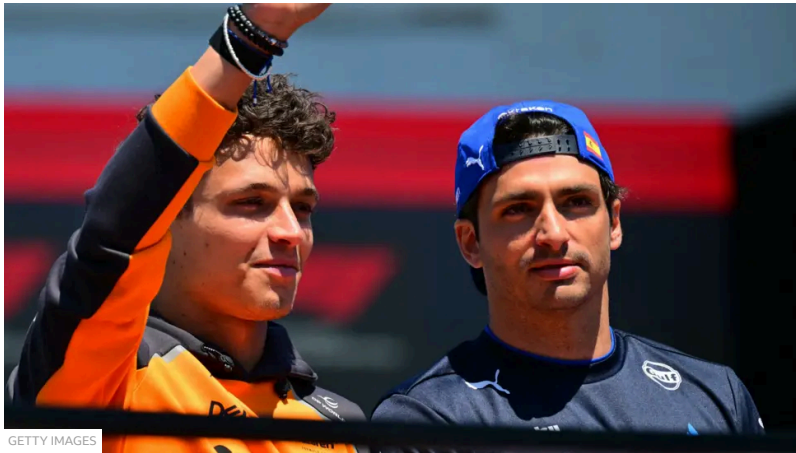
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Norris' openness used against him - Sainz



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F1 Correspondent at the Hungaroring

1 August 2025

Hungarian Grand Prix

Venue: Hungaroring **Dates:** 1-3 August **Race start:** 14:00 BST on Sunday**Coverage:** Live commentary of practice and qualifying on BBC Radio 5 Sports Extra 2 with race on BBC Radio 5 Live; live text updates on BBC Sport website and app**McLaren driver Lando Norris' openness in admitting his frailties is "used against him", according to his former team-mate Carlos Sainz.**

Sainz, who partnered Norris at McLaren from 2019-20 and has remained friends with the Briton, told BBC 5 live Sport: "He opens [up] to the media and to people more than any other driver on the grid - and people use that against him."

Sainz, who now drives for Williams, said: "What you see on TV is what he is as a human being. He's very good at showing himself.

"I sometimes find it a bit ironic and a bit frustrating. He is probably the only guy being 100% genuine on his feelings and the way he thinks but then people are going back at him."

Norris ended Friday practice at the Hungarian Grand Prix fastest by 0.291 seconds from team-mate Oscar Piastri.

Norris is 16 points behind the Australian before this race, which marks the end of the first part of the season before Formula 1's summer break.

Sainz said Norris being criticised for his openness was "a bit sad" because "probably the 19 other drivers have a similar level of doubt and a similar level of self-criticism inside their heads, they just don't explain it out loud because we prefer to keep it inside and not say it to the media".

Norris has admitted that he has made errors this season that have cost him points.

Earlier in the year, Norris was struggling with a lack of feel from the front axle of the car, which made it difficult for him to anticipate its behaviour when he was pushing to the limit.

McLaren have made a change to the front suspension to improve this aspect of the car for him, and Norris has been more comfortable since the Canadian Grand Prix in June.

Nevertheless, Norris made errors on his qualifying laps in Canada that left him sixth on the grid, and crashed into Piastri after a misjudgement during the race.

He then won in Austria, and inherited victory at the British Grand Prix when Piastri was penalised for his driving behind a safety car.

Norris then took pole in Belgium last weekend but was overtaken on the first lap by Piastri, who went on to win.

Asked about Norris' prospects of beating Piastri to the championship this year, Sainz said: "If I base my decision on speed and talent, I'm 100% sure he has that to win a World Championship.

"But F1 also involves a bit of luck, mental resilience, being at home with a car in the right times.

"It doesn't really matter if he doesn't win this year, he'll get another chance. He has 10-15 years in F1. He has the potential, talent and speed.

"If he gets it this year, great I'll be happy for him. If not, he might get his chance later."

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What happened in practice?

Norris topped both sessions of Friday practice from Piastri at the Hungaroring, with Ferrari's Charles Leclerc third each time.

Norris' advantage in the first session was 0.019secs and although the gap between the two was bigger in the later hour, neither driver had an ideal run. Norris had to abort his first flying lap after a mistake at Turn Two, while Piastri had heavy traffic on his fastest.

Norris then had a narrow escape at the final corner when he got his outside front wheel on the grass turning in, and ran wide into the run-off area.

Norris said: "The car since the first lap has felt pretty good. All my laps have been decent. The second session was a bit more messy, just a few more mistakes, but that's all part of practice and trying to find the limit in different areas.

"I know what I want from the car but it might be a bit harder trying to get it."

Piastri said: "The performance has been very good. Some things to tidy up. It wasn't the smoothest of P2s but excited for the rest of the weekend.

Behind Leclerc, the Aston Martins of Lance Stroll and Fernando Alonso were fourth and fifth, even though the Spaniard missed the first session to give himself more time to recover from a muscle problem in his back.

Lewis Hamilton was sixth fastest, 0.306secs slower than team-mate Leclerc and appearing to struggle with rear-end stability on the evidence of several oversteer snaps that sent him into the run-off area at the chicane.

Mercedes driver George Russell was seventh, ahead of Racing Bulls' Isack Hadjar, Red Bull's Yuki Tsunoda and Mercedes' Kimi Antonelli.

Red Bull's Max Verstappen was in 14th, and said: "Today was really tough, just a low-grip feeling and not really a balance in the car. It's difficult to say what is the exact problem, nothing really worked."

Verstappen had to see the stewards after the session because he threw a towel out of the car at one point during the session. The stewards issued a warning to Red Bull.

Verstappen said: "It was just a towel that you wipe your face with when you come back in. It was still in the car when I went out so instead of it maybe potentially getting in between my feet, which is the dangerous part, I drove off line and got rid of it in the safest way possible. I think the stewards understand that."

Listen to the Sainz interview in 5 live Sport's Lando Norris special show at 2030 UK time on Friday

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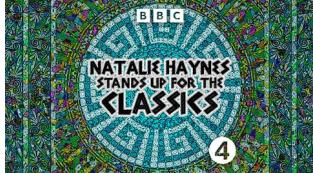
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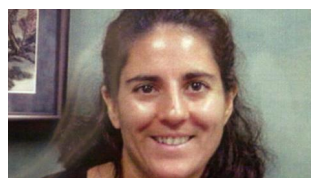
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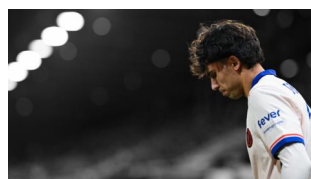
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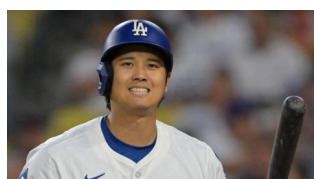
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